

A 99-Year-Old Grandma Walked to Make Freedom Day a Real Holiday!

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Imagine waiting more than two years to hear the best news ever! That's what happened to 250,000 **enslaved** people in Texas. In 1863, President Lincoln said they were free. But **plantation owners** hid the truth. Finally, on June 19, 1865, **Union soldiers** arrived in **Galveston** and shouted, "You're free!" The joy exploded into dancing, prayers, and big cookouts. That celebration became **Juneteenth**. But for a long time, it wasn't an official holiday everywhere. That bugged Opal Lee, a grandma from Texas. In 2016, when she was 89, she started walking. She walked 2.5 miles in cities all the way from Fort Worth to Washington, DC. Why 2.5 miles? It stood for the 2.5 years people waited to learn they were free. Her feet and her heart made a difference. In 2021, President Biden signed a law making **Juneteenth** a **federal holiday**. Now 99, Opal says, "**Juneteenth** is not a Black thing, and it's not a Texas thing. We all bleed red blood." So this June 19, grab some barbecue and remember: freedom is for everyone!

Word Treasure

enslaved -- People who were owned by others and forced to work without pay.

plantation owners -- Wealthy farmers who owned large farms and forced enslaved people to work.

Union soldiers -- Fighters from the northern states during the Civil War who helped end slavery.

Galveston -- A city on the coast of Texas where the last enslaved people learned they were free.

Juneteenth -- A holiday on June 19 celebrating the day enslaved people in Texas finally got their freedom.

federal holiday -- A holiday that the whole country officially recognizes, like New Year's Day.

Background you need

The Emancipation Proclamation by President Abraham Lincoln in 1863 declared freedom for enslaved people in Confederate states, but plantation owners often hid the news to keep their workers.

Opal Lee (a retired teacher and activist from Fort Worth, Texas, sometimes called the 'Grandmother of Juneteenth') began her walking campaign at age 89 to persuade the whole country to honor this important day.

Galveston, a city on the Texas coast, is where Union soldiers finally arrived in 1865 to enforce the proclamation, sparking celebrations that became Juneteenth.

Break it down

WHO: Opal Lee, a determined 99-year-old grandma from Texas.

WHAT: She walked 2.5 miles in cities across the country to push for Juneteenth to become a national holiday.

WHERE: From Fort Worth, Texas all the way to Washington, DC.

WHY: Because the 2.5 years enslaved people waited for freedom deserved to be remembered by everyone as a celebration of freedom for all.

Why it matters

Opal Lee's story shows that one person, no matter how old, can change the country's calendar so that everyone remembers how important freedom is.

Test what you remember

1. How long did enslaved people in Texas wait to hear they were free?

- ☐ (A) a few days
- ☐ (B) 2.5 years
- ☐ (C) 5 years
- ☐ (D) 10 years

2. What did Union soldiers announce in Galveston?

- ☐ (A) That a new president was elected
- ☐ (B) That the war was starting
- ☐ (C) That all enslaved people were free
- ☐ (D) That they were building a new school

3. Why did Opal Lee walk 2.5 miles in many cities?

- ☐ (A) To raise money for her church
- ☐ (B) To match the 2.5 years of waiting for freedom
- ☐ (C) To train for a marathon
- ☐ (D) To visit all 50 states

4. Who signed the law making Juneteenth a federal holiday?

- ☐ (A) President Abraham Lincoln
- ☐ (B) President Joe Biden
- ☐ (C) Opal Lee
- ☐ (D) Grant Hackett

5. What does Opal Lee say about Juneteenth?

- ☐ (A) It is only for Black people
- ☐ (B) It is only a Texas holiday
- ☐ (C) It is not a Black thing or a Texas thing, but for all people
- ☐ (D) It should be replaced by another holiday

6. What did people do when they first heard they were free?

- ☐ (A) They went back to work quietly
- ☐ (B) They danced, prayed, and had big cookouts
- ☐ (C) They moved to another country
- ☐ (D) They built new houses

Answer key (try the quiz first!): 1: B 2: C 3: B 4: B 5: C 6: B

Questions to think about

1. Opal Lee and supporters: They believe Juneteenth should be a national holiday so all Americans can learn about the end of slavery and celebrate freedom together. The 2.5-mile walks turned her personal mission into a movement.

2. Some Texans who already celebrated: For many Black Texans, Juneteenth was already a cherished local tradition. Some worried that making it a federal holiday might water down its meaning, but Opal Lee sees the national recognition as a way to share joy and history with everyone.

MY THOUGHTS (at least 20 words):